

India Unstoppable

India's digital economy is on track to contribute a fifth of the GDP by 2026 and help the country reach the goal of a \$5-trillion economy

IT IS CERTAINLY that time of the year or life of the government when you start looking forward, after looking back, and start engaging in conversations about what the future will look like based on the effort and progress made in the past 10 years. It's a legitimate question, something that most Indians must ponder. Because, over the past 10 years, even the worst cynic on the planet will agree that India has certainly transformed in multiple ways.

There is a new political culture that is visible—a culture of performance, one that delivers. There is a governance framework that is extremely visible. It's responsive and connected to almost every citizen using technology and innovation. And there is ambition. And, therefore, under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the nation is aspiring to even more growth and greatness.

So, looking at the past 10 years and forward to this dream that was never imaginable in our lifetime before—of achieving the status of first the third-largest economy in the world and then becoming a developed nation within 100 years of independence—it is certainly something that we should understand and talk about.

I have been a minister for about two years, after the PM gave me this incredible opportunity, and I have served before that for several years as a Member of Parliament. For a large part of those years, I was



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in the opposition—from 2006 to 2014. I saw how, at every stage, the narrative of India would go from bad to worse. In 2014, we were classified as a fragile five country. We had tech and electronics manufacturing sectors and an innovation economy that were really hampered by a lack of leadership and support from the Government of India. Companies wanted to set up semiconductor plants in India in 2012, but the government lacked vision. Even in an area like telecom, with which I have long been associated, after 10–15 years of its existence, it was beset with scams and crony capitalism. That, in a sense, defined the rest of the digital economy as well.

If you had asked me in 2014 or 2013 what India's future would look like, I would certainly have been disconsolate, not terribly optimistic, and reasonably shy of predicting anything, like a billion Indians. But here we are 10 years on, and if you ask me now to look forward to any of the segments that I am associated with—technology, electronics, manufacturing, innovation, semiconductors, artificial intelligence (AI), talent, and skills in areas like higher education—I can tell you in a nutshell that I am deeply optimistic about us going from the fifth-largest economy to becoming the third-largest in a very short time.

The digital economy used to contribute about 4.5% of the GDP in 2014, but is set to be about 20%

INVESTMENTS IN SEMICONDUCTORS, ELECTRONICS, PLI, ETC., AND ALLIANCES WITH THE US, EU, JAPAN AND SOUTH KOREA ARE BUILDING BLOCKS FOR A \$1 TRILLION-PLUS DIGITAL ECONOMY